

Hydrotherapy for Arthritis: Benefits, Access and What to

Complete UK guide to hydrotherapy for arthritis. Learn about warm-water therapy benefits, finding NHS hydrotherapy pools, what happens in a session and costs.

By **Living With Arthritis Editorial Team** · Reviewed by **Clinical Advisory Panel** (HCPC-registered physiotherapy & rheumatology nursing input) · 2026-01-06 · livingwitharthritis.org.uk



*Person performing gentle exercises in a hydrotherapy pool for arthritis rehabilitation
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Hydrotherapy — exercise in warm water, typically 33–36°C — is one of the most effective and enjoyable treatments for arthritis. The combination of warmth, buoyancy

and water resistance creates an ideal exercise environment where joints can move freely with minimal pain. Recommended by NICE, the NHS and Arthritis UK, hydrotherapy has a strong evidence base for improving pain, stiffness, strength and function in both osteoarthritis and inflammatory arthritis. This guide explains the benefits, helps you access NHS hydrotherapy services and tells you what to expect.

How Hydrotherapy Helps Arthritis

Buoyancy

When immersed to waist depth, your body weight is reduced by approximately 50%. At chest depth, weight-bearing stress is reduced by up to 80%. This allows movements that would be painful on land to be performed with significantly less joint loading. People who struggle to walk comfortably on land often find they can walk, squat and exercise freely in water.

Warmth

Hydrotherapy pools are heated to 33–36°C (compared to standard swimming pools at 26–28°C). This warmth relaxes muscles, increases blood flow to joints, reduces pain perception and improves the elasticity of connective tissues. Many people describe the immediate relief of entering warm water as one of the most pleasant experiences of their arthritis management.

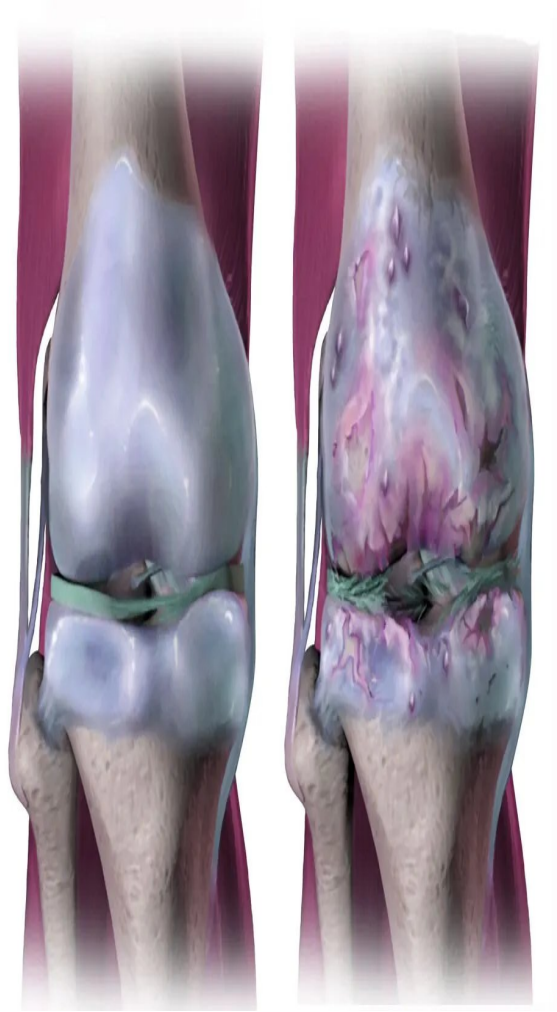
Hydrostatic Pressure

The pressure of water around the body reduces swelling in joints and limbs, provides support during movement, and improves circulation. This is particularly beneficial for people with swollen ankles, knees or hands.

Resistance

Water provides natural resistance to movement — approximately 12 times more resistance than air. This means exercises performed in water provide muscle strengthening without the need for weights or equipment. The resistance is proportional to speed, so you can control the intensity simply by moving faster or slower.

What the Evidence Says



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- A Cochrane review found aquatic exercise significantly improved pain, function and quality of life in knee and hip OA
- Research published in Physical Therapy found hydrotherapy produced greater improvements in pain and function than land-based exercise for knee OA
- A systematic review in Rheumatology found that aquatic exercise was beneficial for RA, improving joint tenderness, mood and overall well-being
- NICE recommends hydrotherapy as part of multimodal management for OA
- Benefits typically appear within 4–6 weeks of regular sessions

What Happens in a Hydrotherapy Session

A typical NHS hydrotherapy session lasts 30–45 minutes and is led by a physiotherapist or specialist hydrotherapy assistant:

- Assessment — Before your first session, a physiotherapist will assess your joints, mobility and goals
- Warm-up — Gentle walking and arm movements in the water
- Exercises — Tailored exercises targeting your specific joints — may include walking, squats, leg lifts, arm exercises, stretches and balance work
- Cool-down — Gentle stretches and relaxation in the warm water

Sessions may be individual (one-to-one with a therapist) or group-based (typically 4–8 people). Group sessions are social and motivating, while individual sessions allow more tailored exercises.

Accessing NHS Hydrotherapy



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- GP referral — Ask your GP to refer you to physiotherapy, specifically requesting hydrotherapy if available locally
- Direct physiotherapy referral — Many NHS trusts accept self-referrals to physiotherapy
- Rheumatology team — If you're under a rheumatologist, they can refer directly to hydrotherapy
- Waiting times — Typically 4–12 weeks, though this varies by area
- Course length — Usually 6–12 sessions

Finding Hydrotherapy Pools

Dedicated hydrotherapy pools exist at many NHS hospitals, community health centres, some private physiotherapy clinics and charity facilities (Arthritis UK lists some). Not all areas

have easy access — if NHS hydrotherapy is unavailable, many public leisure centres offer "warm water" or "gentle aqua" sessions in pools heated to higher temperatures than standard.

Private Hydrotherapy

Private hydrotherapy sessions typically cost £40–£80 per session. Some private health insurance covers hydrotherapy with a GP or consultant referral. Private sessions usually have shorter waiting times and more flexibility in scheduling.

Swimming vs Hydrotherapy

While both involve water, they differ significantly. Hydrotherapy pools are warmer (33–36°C vs 26–28°C), smaller and shallower with easy access (ramps, hoists). Sessions are supervised and exercises tailored to individual needs. Standard swimming is excellent exercise for arthritis but doesn't provide the same therapeutic warmth. Both are beneficial — hydrotherapy is typically more appropriate for those with severe symptoms, while regular swimming maintains fitness once symptoms are better controlled.

Tips for Getting the Most from Hydrotherapy

- Continue your exercises at home between sessions — your physiotherapist will give you a home programme
- Arrive early to shower and change at a relaxed pace
- Bring a water bottle — you can get dehydrated in warm water without realising
- Rest afterwards if needed — warm-water exercise can be tiring initially
- After your NHS course ends, continue with public pool sessions to maintain benefits

Hydrotherapy is one of the most effective and enjoyable treatments available for arthritis. If you haven't tried it, ask your GP about access. Our virtual assistant can help you find hydrotherapy pools and warm-water exercise classes near you.

This article is for general information only. Hydrotherapy may not be suitable if you have certain medical conditions (uncontrolled blood pressure, open wounds, certain infections). Your physiotherapist will assess suitability.

Q&A

Question: What is the key thing to know about hydrotherapy for arthritis uk: benefits, access and what to ?

Short answer: Hydrotherapy is exercising in warm water, typically 33–36°C, helping arthritis by reducing body weight, allowing easier movement. The warmth relaxes muscles and lessens pain, while water resistance builds strength. NHS sessions, usually 30–45 minutes, are led by a physiotherapist, with courses often lasting 6–12 weeks. Access is usually via GP or rheumatologist referral.

Question: When should I seek professional advice?

Short answer: If symptoms persist or worsen, pain is severe and unresponsive to usual relief, or you develop new symptoms, contact your GP, physiotherapist or rheumatology team promptly.

Question: Where can I get free arthritis support in the UK?

Short answer: Arthritis UK: 0800 5200 520. NRAS: 0800 298 7650. Free tools and guides at livingwitharthritis.org.uk.

General information only — not medical advice. Consult your GP or specialist before changing medication or starting a new programme. Emergency: 999. NHS advice: 111. Living With Arthritis · livingwitharthritis.org.uk